

any time when the platform was unavailable. I am sure there have been occasions in the past when we have had some downtime, but I cannot attribute it to the use of open source. I have worked on non-open source software as well, and if something goes wrong with the platform, I know it is because the developer or deployer has made a mistake.

Q What are the advantages of using open source in your organisation?

There are many. First of all, the total cost of ownership is significantly lower. The cost of ownership is often underestimated, but when you are not paying maintenance fees year after year, you get what you want at zero cost, effectively, all other things being the same. The organisation has saved a significant amount of money by using open source. Considering the minimum costs that would be incurred—cost of software, licence, maintenance fees, appropriate plug-ins to run the platform, etc—the savings would add up to thousands of dollars.

Moreover, the community support you get while resolving issues is critical. You always know that there is a community out there to fall back upon. Of course, on the flip side, there can be times when the support is not immediately forthcoming or adequate and then we know we will have to dig deeper ourselves. But in general, knowing that you have a community you can tap into is very comforting. You need not sign up for an expensive maintenance contract and wait for the vendors to respond to you each time you have an issue. The fact that the tools are already available keeps TutorVista on the open source track.

Q Does TutorVista regularly communicate with the online open source community?

We have not approached the community seeking help yet, but we know that by going down this path, we can easily modify and reuse an open source tool with the community's help. That knowledge gives us the confidence that we do not have to build everything from scratch, but we can depend on the community in terms of using, developing or modifying open source tools.

Q What challenges did you face on the open source track?

TutorVista still faces trouble in searching for good database administrators (DBAs). We use the online forums and the reams of literature that's available to solve our problems.

We have a good team of people who know open source technologies. With regard to setting up servers, we always had people who knew how to set up a Linux server, handle Apache servers and how to secure them. The only area where we have faced challenges is primarily on the MySQL database. MySQL is a great database in terms of what open source can provide, but the challenge lies in finding the right DBAs for MySQL. If you consider databases like Oracle or SQL Server, there are full-fledged training programs behind them. Since MySQL runs more on a do-it-on-your-own principle, you will not find many DBAs lining up for certification in MySQL, unlike Oracle.

Q Lately, have you seen a rise in the use of open source among enterprises?

The proliferation of open source frameworks that are being used by companies does indicate that there are a lot of people using open source. Recently, I realised that Walmart uses Wicket – this is an example of open source being used by a pretty big company.

The availability of tools and a sense of community are some of the main attractions of open source. This is one of the main reasons we see an increase in the use of open source at an enterprise-level. If an educational company is setting up a learning environment system, it can buy proprietary tools like Blackboard or it can use an open source alternative like Moodle. The latter does not have all the features that Blackboard has, but open source developers are constantly adding more features to it. So overall, it is a win-win situation for all.

Q In which sectors do you see this increase?

The increase is evident mainly in e-commerce and education. It helps that many open source frameworks and components are being built for an e-commerce environment. This way, it is easier to put an e-commerce website together using these frameworks rather than developing it from scratch. Components in PHP, Open Cart, Presta Shop, etc, are built keeping in mind typical activities that go into an e-commerce site.

Q What advice do you have for enterprises or start-ups that are considering the use of open source?

Start-ups should find out how to minimise costs in the right places. Web development is one of the areas where you can avoid the additional costs of hardware or software maintenance. You can take a look at how similar tools have been used in other places and evaluate them before going down that path. At times, implementing a tool can reveal that it is quite different from what you imagined. For instance, in e-commerce, let us consider Open Cart. You know what it provides and you know how it works in other websites. You can co-relate it to what you want, go through the documentation and do a quick prototype. If the prototype itself is very effort-intensive, it is an indicator that the solution will not be efficient. Within a day or two, you will know whether it is easy to use or not. You can do a cost-benefit analysis to check how an organisation can benefit from open source in comparison to proprietary solutions. When it comes to big enterprises, they are more monolithic, top-heavy and not as agile as smaller companies. In such cases, proprietary tools and solutions may help because in cases where something goes wrong, you will have guaranteed support. 

By: Jalaja Ramanunni

The author is a journalist at the EFY Group. She is a fan of anything portable, and loves exploring different genres of music and movies.